

Most of the time, interactions between humans and sharks occur without harm to the humans, but in the rare cases where there is an attack, lots of media coverage tends to follow.¹⁷²

In reality, the risk is very low. More people were killed by mosquitoes last year than have been killed by sharks in the past 100 years. Indeed, annual deaths from selfies exceed yearly shark fatalities. As we discuss later, you are much more likely to die from a medical error—the third largest cause of death in the US—than from a shark attack. What else is more deadly than sharks? Try armed toddlers—young children who happen to get their hands on a firearm.¹⁷³ But shark attacks are more memorable and dramatic, and therefore readily and easily recalled.

Which brings us back to anecdotes: As it turns out, the original quote about anecdotes had a very different context, and a much more nuanced meaning. It is attributed to Ray Wolfinger, who was a political scientist at the University of California, Berkeley.¹⁷⁴

Wolfinger's original statement was quite literally the very opposite of the quote we all have been using. He had actually said “the plural of anecdote is data.” This might affect how we should think about and use narratives and data.

The earliest discussion I could track down of the original quote was via the American Dialect Society. Fred Shapiro, former editor of the *Yale Dictionary of Quotations*, had an email exchange with the professor about the statement's origins.¹⁷⁵ Wolfinger recalled responding to a student's dismissal of a factual statement as a mere anecdote, and told Shapiro: “It was meant to suggest that data does not have an immaculate birth, and that anecdotes lead to deeper research and then data.”

The professor's take was not a warning against extrapolation or anecdotal evidence. If anything, he was encouraging data scientists to delve deeper into their experiences to discover fertile new areas for research and exploration. To the alert observer, a compelling anecdote should start the